

"Controlling or imposing on children is not a healthy way to tackle them."



JITENDRA NAGPAL,
Psychiatrist,
VIMHANS, Delhi

"After a certain age, children need parents to be role models."



VANDANA LULLA,
Principal, Podar
International School,
Mumbai

"Hovering parents can make children feel stifled and frustrated."



SANJAY CHUGH,
Psychiatrist, Dr
Chugh's Clinic, Delhi

OVERZEALOUS PARENTS CAN TURN INTO A TEACHER'S NIGHTMARE.



REUBEN SINGH

VIGILANT

Neenu Nayyar, 35
Shameen Nayyar, 13
NOIDA

Neenu mingles with her daughter's friends to make sure she is in good company; knows her daughter's syllabus by heart; waits around a mall when her daughter hangs out with friends.

"SHE NEVER HIDES ANYTHING FROM ME. I MAKE FRIENDS WITH HER FRIENDS TOO."

Whenever Shameen goes to a mall with her friends, Nayyar drops her off, hangs around in the vicinity until she is ready to leave, and then brings her back.

This kind of hovering, Chugh believes, can frustrate children and make them feel stifled. The effect is that children often begin to rebel. "Setting boundaries is a good practice, but we also need to give them the space to move within those limits," he says. Vandana Lulla, principal of Mumbai's Podar International School, adds, "It restricts child's development and growth. They become so dependent, usually on the mother, that they can't, for instance, handle themselves on school trips." Shah admits that her elder daughter feels uncomfortable when she isn't around, though she is quick to add that she doesn't think it's a bad thing. "In fact, since I have focused so much on my elder daughter, her sister is growing up in a

relatively carefree manner."

It's not that children don't need to be monitored or guided. Lulla says, "After a certain age, they need a different kind of attention. Parents need to be good role models. A lot of learning happens at home. A child notices how his parents behave and picks up from the environment." Says Nagpal, "There needs to be a balance between protective parenting and permissive parenting. The household needs to be a democratic set-up. Parents should be authoritative, but not authoritarian; they need to discuss discipline and responsibilities."

So parents, take a deep breath, a step back and reevaluate. There are healthier ways of approaching your kids and their looming future crises, ones that are not controlling or imposing. Turn off the rotor for a while; allow them the space to grow. They'll thank you for it later. ■